large contingent departed for the Punjab. En route they were joined by additional troops which included a master artilleryman under whose training Akbar ‘became as much a master of this art as masters of a single art and craft are’.

In the Deenpanah, which had been taken over in the interim and added to by Sher Shah Sur, Humayun introduced a host of new inventions to his court. Drummers now announced the Padshah’s arrival and, when Humayun rose to leave the court, muskets were fired. He wore garments according to a strict colour code he had created to align with the planets, and two-storey barges he had designed sailed on the Yamuna. Scholar A. Azfar Moin has shown that many of the mysterious and elaborate ceremonies that Humayun developed at his court to bolster his own claims to a sacred kingship for the Mughals in Hindustan were influenced by his time spent at the Persian Safavid court. Moin demonstrates that far from being the ‘eccentric dilettante’ of modern rhetoric, Humayun attempted to create a legitimate source of power by using Sufic symbols, equally appropriate in Hindustan’s landscape as it had been in Persia’s, and provided his successors with some powerful sacred symbolism. Humayun also introduced the system of mansab[†] for his officers in lieu of the earlier ‘beg’ and adopted some of Sher Shah Sur’s important administrative measures as described by Eaton:

> These included…division of the kingdom’s administration into fixed territorial units, or sarkars, subdivided in districts, or parganas. From Sher Shah’s administration on, revenue and judicial officers were posted at both sarkar and pargana levels, thereby ensuring an orderly system of land-revenue assessment and collection. Further, to centralize his administration, Humayun designated as much revenue-producing land as possible as khalisa, or land administered directly by the state, rather than by nobles.

The system of assigning a mansab to an officer—linking the strength of the contingent expected of him to his revenue from assigned territories in a fixed ratio—had been accepted by both Babur and Humayun when they encountered it in Hindustan. As we will see later, Akbar would use this system to good effect.

Humayun seems to have had an intimation of his own end during the last months of his life. He became melancholic, spoke of dreams and auguries and, even more ominously, slowly reduced his consumption of